Parenting Plan Template

Discussion worksheet for separated parents in Australia · Mediations Australia · Version 1.0, 8 November 2026 · mediationsaustralia.com.au/parenting-plan-template/

Important – please read first. This worksheet helps parents discuss and write down practical arrangements for their children. It is general information, not legal advice, and it is **not a court document**. A parenting plan is not a court order and is not enforceable in the same way. If you already have parenting orders, get legal advice before agreeing to anything different. If there is family violence, abuse or a risk to anyone's safety, do not use this worksheet to negotiate directly: call 000 in an emergency or 1800RESPECT on 1800 737 732, and get professional help.

How to use this worksheet

- Work through each section and write down what you agree. Leave a section blank if it does not apply.
- Be specific: days, times, places and who is responsible.
- Focus on your children's needs, ages and routines. There is no automatic starting point of equal time.
- A parenting plan must be in writing, dated and signed by both parents (Family Relationships Online). It can include ways to change arrangements and resolve disagreements, and it can be renegotiated over time.
- If you cannot agree, a family dispute resolution practitioner can help. Sessions do not have to be in the same room; telephone, video or separate-room arrangements may be available.

Parenting plan or consent orders?

Parenting plan	A written, dated agreement signed by both parents. Flexible and can be renegotiated. Not a court order.
Consent orders	Orders made by the Court on agreed terms, after it considers the child's best interests. Enforceable as court orders. Get legal advice before applying.

1. Parents and children

Parent 1 name	
Parent 2 name	
Child's name and date of birth	
Child's name and date of birth	
Child's name and date of birth	
Any special needs, health or routine considerations	

2. Living arrangements and regular time

Where the children will mainly live (if one home)	
School-term schedule: which days and nights with each parent	
Start date of this schedule	
How the schedule may change as the children get older	

3. School holidays and special days

School holidays (how each holiday period is shared)	
Christmas and New Year	
Easter	
Mother's Day and Father's Day	
Children's birthdays	
Parents' birthdays and other important days (cultural or religious)	

4. Transport and changeovers

Where changeovers happen (e.g. school, a neutral place)	
Who is responsible for transport, and when	
What happens if someone is running late or needs to change a time	

5. Communication

How parents will communicate about the children (e.g. app, email)	
How and when children can contact the other parent	
Expected response times for non-urgent messages	
How urgent matters (illness, emergencies) are communicated	

6. Education and health decisions

How major long-term decisions are made (schooling, health, religion)	
School: who attends parent–teacher meetings and events, and receives reports	
Health: doctors, Medicare cards, medication and appointments	

7. Sharing information

What information each parent shares (school notices, medical updates, activities)	

8. Expenses discussion

This section is for discussing day-to-day costs such as activities or uniforms. It does not replace child support arrangements administered by Services Australia. Get advice about child support separately.

Extra-curricular activities and sport	
School costs (uniforms, excursions, devices)	
Medical or dental costs not covered elsewhere	

9. Travel

Notice required for interstate or overseas travel	
Passports: who holds them and consent arrangements	
Itinerary and contact details while travelling	

10. Review and resolving disagreements

When the plan will be reviewed (e.g. each year, or when a child starts school)	
What parents will do if they disagree (e.g. talk first, then family dispute resolution)	
How changes will be recorded (a new dated and signed version)	

Signatures

A parenting plan must be in writing, dated and signed by both parents. Children do not sign this plan.

Parent 1 signature	
Date	
Parent 2 signature	
Date	

Where to get help. Family Relationship Advice Line: 1800 050 321 (familyrelationships.gov.au). Mediations Australia: mediationsaustralia.com.au/contact-us/. For legal advice, contact a family lawyer, Legal Aid or a community legal centre in your state or territory. Western Australia has its own Family Court and procedures.